

Don't view your mistakes in isolation

I'd like you to think, for a moment, about reality TV. Imagine that you are in the editing room, watching things unfold. Access to a 24-hour loop of a whole medley of human behaviour – the good, the bad and the ugly. Now, imagine that your boss has told you that one person in this room must be painted as the villain, and that you need to cut out any provocations or situations that might make their actions understandable. Would that be fair?

Now, this is actually a well-documented phenomenon; lots of people have waltzed off reality TV shows expecting applause, only to be met with boos, thanks in part to their own behaviour but also because of all of the bits that *weren't* shown. The context that was edited out for dramatic effect, the unseen provocations and influences that led them to react in a particular way. We do ourselves a great disservice when we recreate that editing room in our own minds, cropping our mistakes right down to the action itself and removing any context or nuance, because the circumstances under which we make our decisions *matter*. They matter so much that it's not really possible to understand, and then correct, our behaviour without a comprehensive view of where we've gone wrong and why.

As much as some people are determined to conflate the two, reasons are not excuses. Accountability does not have to mean giving yourself a hard time in spite of difficult circumstances